Password and Authentication Standards

Organization: Meridian Technologies

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Department: IT and Security

Team: Cybersecurity

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1. Purpose

This document establishes password management and authentication requirements for users accessing Meridian Technologies' internal applications and infrastructure.

The Cybersecurity team is responsible for defining authentication standards and monitoring authentication-related security risks.

2. Password Requirements

All employee accounts must use passwords that satisfy the following minimum requirements:

- Minimum length of 12 characters.
- At least one uppercase letter.
- At least one lowercase letter.
- At least one numerical digit.
- At least one special character.

Passwords must not contain easily guessed information such as employee names or organizational usernames.

Previously compromised passwords must not be reused.

3. Password Storage

Applications must never store plaintext passwords.

Passwords must be processed using an approved password hashing algorithm with appropriate work factors and unique salts.

Authentication systems must not expose password hashes through ordinary API responses.

Passwords must not appear in application logs, error messages or monitoring dashboards.

4. Multi-Factor Authentication

Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for administrative access and privileged infrastructure operations.

The organization supports approved authenticator-based verification mechanisms.

Sensitive administrative operations may require additional authentication confirmation.

5. Login Attempt Restrictions

To reduce unauthorized login attempts, Meridian applies the following controls:

Control	Requirement
Failed login threshold	5 consecutive attempts
Temporary account lockout	15 minutes
Password reset verification	Required
Privileged account MFA	Mandatory
Suspicious login review	Cybersecurity

	investigation

Repeated authentication failures may trigger security alerts.

6. Password Reset Procedure

Employees requesting password resets must complete the approved identity verification process.

Password reset links or temporary credentials must be delivered through an approved communication mechanism.

Temporary passwords must be changed during the next successful login.

IT Support must not request an employee's existing password.

7. Session Management

Applications must enforce session expiration and secure token handling.

Inactive sessions should expire after 30 minutes for privileged interfaces unless an approved application requirement specifies otherwise.

Authentication tokens must not be stored in publicly accessible locations.

8. Security Responsibilities

Employees must not share passwords or reuse organizational credentials on unrelated external websites.

Suspected credential compromise must be reported immediately to Cybersecurity.

The Cybersecurity team investigates suspicious authentication events and coordinates account suspension when required.

9. Related Documents

- IT-001: Enterprise Access Control Policy
- IT-005: Security Incident Handling Playbook
- HR-002: Employee Handbook
- ENG-001: Backend Platform Architecture and API Design

10. Version History

Version	Date	Description
1.0	2026-02-05	Initial authentication standards

Document Owner: Security Manager